

Returning the Gaze

Robotic Installation for Milan Fashion Week

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ABSTRACT

Industrial robots have long been used for manufacturing and research purposes around the world. More recently they have also been used in the fields of art, performance, dance, and interaction design, where they have served as a collaborator, autonomous agent, and, in some cases, as an extension of the artist. This project explores how a robotic extension could engage with the critical feminist issue of “the male gaze.” In doing so, it provides a brief theoretical context to the notion of the gaze in the context of visual culture and feminism. Finally, it illustrates the application of such a critical concept through the example of a robotic installation developed by the author for Milan Fashion Week in collaboration with Universal Robots. It engages with ways in which robots might extend the gaze through to discourses of resistance, whereby the gaze could be used to empower those who typically face discrimination.

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1 PROJECT URL

<https://behnazfarahi.com/returning-the-gaze/>

2 INTRODUCTION: BIAS AND THE MALE GAZE

In his book, *Ways of Seeing*, art critic John Berger analyzes the ways in which men and women are represented in visual culture through different “gazes,” or ways in which they are looked at. He argues that historically men have been portrayed as though they are allowed to examine women, while women must continually watch themselves [Berger 1990]. Three years later, feminist film theorist, Laura Mulvey, published her seminal article, *Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema* [Mulvey 1975]. As she observes, the male gaze serves to depict women as the object of pleasure for the heterosexual male viewer. It is as though women are under perpetual surveillance from the male gaze. She demonstrates the asymmetry of power relations between the observer and the observed where the unwanted gaze may be experienced as a form of violation. She explains, “thus the woman as icon, displayed for

the gaze and enjoyment of men, the active controllers of the look, always threatens to evoke the anxiety it originally signified”.

Reflecting on ‘value of voyeurism’ and feeling of being observed, the panopticon is one of the most important historical precedents. The panopticon refers to a type of institutional building and a system of control envisioned by the English philosopher, Jeremy Bentham, in the 18th century. French philosopher Michel Foucault revives interest in the panopticon in his 1975 book, *Discipline and Punish*, and uses it to illustrate how such a model could be applied to disciplinary societies in order to control their citizens. He describes the prisoner of a panopticon as being at the receiving end of asymmetrical surveillance. As a consequence, the inmate polices himself or herself for fear of punishment. As Foucault notes, “Hence the major effect of the Panopticon: to induce in the inmate a state of conscious and permanent visibility that assures the automatic functioning of power.” [Foucault 1977]

What is fascinating about this example is that the gaze of the watcher is internalized to such an extent that each prisoner becomes his/her own watchperson. “Foucault emphasized the productive potential of surveillance as a technology of statecraft -one by which the state produces the form of state scrutiny is not only the province of external forms of police come to police themselves.” [Dubrofsky and Magnet 2015]. Similarly, we could argue that – more generally – it is this process that allows rules and regulations to be internalized so as to inform our actions, behaviors and even beliefs. Moreover, the manner in which we naturalize and internalize rules, it could be claimed, causes society to be less willing to contest unjust laws and the dominant, accepted outlook. Similar to how the inmates are not aware as to whether or not they are being watched, we are not aware that we are being controlled through naturalized rules rooted in our culture. This internalized asymmetrical power structure could be seen in the notion of ‘male gaze’ in Mulvey’s essay. Besides the fact that women are regularly subject to sexual harassment whenever they enter public space through various forms of ‘looked-at-ness’, women have absorbed all this unconsciously as a form of internalized male gaze. This gaze could be intrusive. It may lead to anxiety, fear, and harassment. In this context, we could ask whether it might be possible for women to be liberated from the objectification of the male gaze. Might women be able to use technology to return the gaze?

3 MILAN FASHION WEEK INSTALLATION

Fashion is an important medium for the production of culture. Yet the fashion industry has long been complicit with a tradition of female objectification and sexual harassment. [Crowley 2021]

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Figure 1: Left: Returning the Gaze: Robotic Installation at the Milan Fashion Show, 2022. Right: The audience is looking at models and the performer with four extended robotic eyes is staring back at onlookers.

Women's bodies are regularly objectified within the fashion industry. Moreover, women have come to absorb this condition unconsciously as a form of the internalized male gaze. But what if we women were to subvert this through the power of our gaze? What if we could use technology to extend and amplify our response? And what if we were to do so on the catwalk itself, where the female model is often subject to sexual harassment through various forms of "looked-at-ness"? What uncanny feelings would this evoke? And what strategies of resistance would it promote?

Returning the Gaze is an exploration of this scenario. It is a robotic performance installed during Milan Fashion Week in collaboration with the Universal Robots and commissioned by ANNAKIKI. In the center, a female model wears a spacesuit-like outfit and a custom-made headpiece fitted with two tiny cameras. The cameras track and capture the movements of the model's eyes, enlarging and displaying them on four monitors mounted on moving robotic arms glaring back at the observer. The gaze of the model is thereby directed back at the viewer, extended and enhanced through cyborgian technologies. This project brings together robotics, fashion, design, feminism and critical thinking in order to critique the asymmetry of social and political power relations between men and women.

4 CONCLUSION

Decades after Haraway's *Cyborg Manifesto*, [Haraway 1987] Elon Musk said "We are already cyborgs". Some might not realize it, but devices and computational systems are already extending our biological capabilities. Using our devices, we memorize names/phone numbers, navigate in our cities, and remember our loved one's birthday. In further developing this cyborgian future, we should raise critical questions as to whether technology could be used to empower those who typically have faced injustice and discrimination. This could engage with culturally and historically sensitive topics such as the male gaze. By describing the robotic installation developed by the author for Milan Fashion Show, this project attempts to build upon the field of critical computation. In this approach, integrating computational technologies should not be seen as an end in itself, but as a means of addressing critical socio-political issues. Contextualized in the feminist discourse of the male gaze, the aim of this project is to reflect on ways we could learn to improve our implicit gaze biases in a manner which might be more inclusive and fair. Furthermore, through their augmented gaze they could force us to reflect on our own very real biases. Returning the

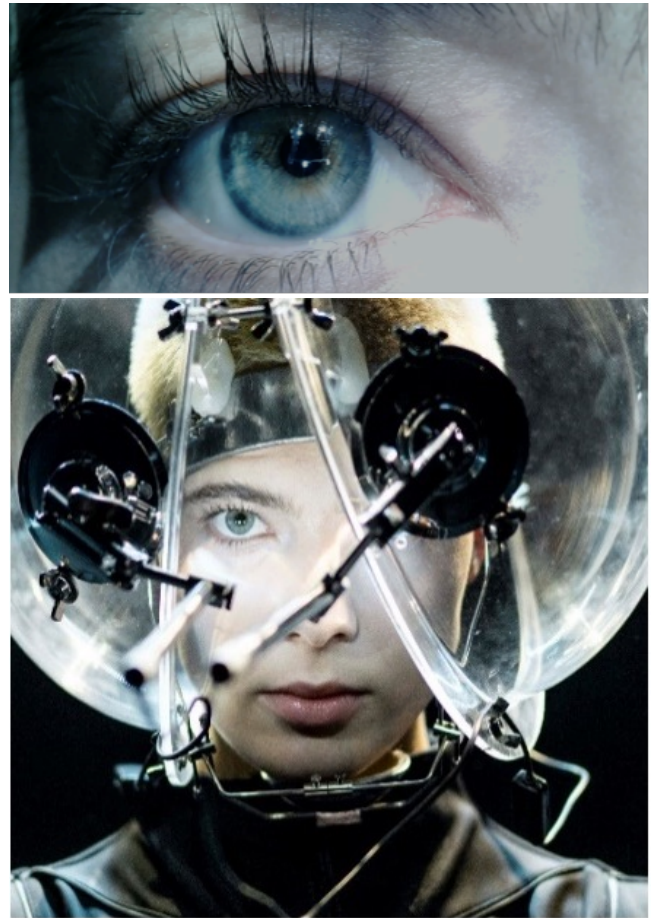


Figure 2: Two microscopic cameras are mounted on the headpiece. They track and stream the performer's eye movements video to the four monitors attached to robotic arms.

Gaze is a step towards a future where our gaze resists disturbing biases, some of which are explicit while others are hidden deep in our subconscious.

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